Chapter Fifty-Five

Seizing the Environmental, Social and Governance Agenda

Roots of ESG Concerns and Issues

In the pre-agriculture era, humans lived as part of the natural eco-system. The food was sourced from the trees and plants and also animals growing and living in the natural state of planet. Everyone could consume whatever was available and necessary for maintenance of body. The natural age was the African age. In the later part of the natural age, humans learnt to make stone tools to secure food better, control fire to make better food and banded together in small numbers to begin living early community life. There was no environmental, social or governance issues in the natural age.

In the agricultural age, humans grew and reared their food. Over the years, human settlements developed and created rich and mighty Chinese, Indian, Sumerian, Egyptian and Greek civilizations. The agriculture surplus birthed kings, princes and the state. Property in land and property in goods and services took shape. The environmental issues created by development of land for agriculture and human settlements did interfere with mother nature, but the issues it spewed were all local and the impacts minimal. Environmental, Social and Governance or the ESG issues began to emerge but were too small and too local to make any difference to the natural state of the planet.

The machine is the principal producer and distributor of goods and services in the industrial economy. Machines, however, are not auto-propelled. Machines need artificial power to make them do work. The artificial power comes from energy. Steam engines came into being first to